

A Cook's TOUR

An itinerant epicure in search of the best eating experiences in the world



EAT MY GLOBE
by SIMON MAJUMDAR
Hachette India
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 278

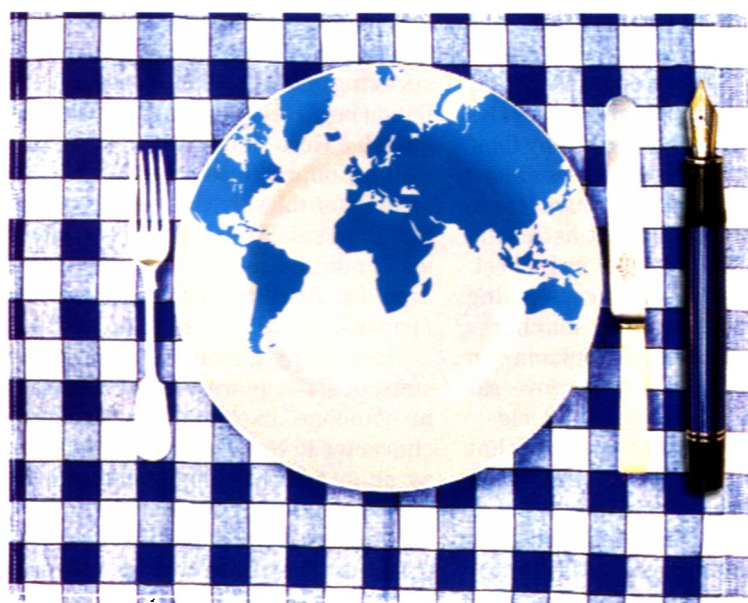
By Dilip Bobb

The Internet is a wondrous invention, not just for information but its ability to create communities of like-minded people and bring about life-changing experiences. Londoner Simon Majumdar is one beneficiary. The son of a Bengali immigrant and a Welsh mother, he has a well paying job in publishing but his real passion is food. Shortly after reaching 40, while stirring a pot of LSD (Life Saving Dahl), he has an epiphany. His job sucks, so does being middle-aged. He starts to list the things he'd like to do before he dies. One is "Go Everywhere, Eat Everything." It's a tall order but for someone so obsessive about food, it's as enticing as the famed ocean trout *confit* at Tetsuya's in Sydney, where he duly arrives, having chucked up his job and embarked on his epicurean adventure.

It's an odyssey which finds him in some truly exotic places tasting even more exotic cuisines, but his travels, and travails, are guided in large part by the digital community of food-lovers he encountered on various internet sites. This book is a result of that gastronomic journey, a cook's tour in a sense. The countries he visits and the food he eats is largely dictated by advice and

invitations from his internet acquaintances. The result is *Eat My Globe*, Majumdar's extreme taste experience in 30 countries, ranging from rotten shark meat in Iceland to braised dog and stir fried rats in China. Cod sperm sushi in Japan, snake stew in Vietnam and camel meat in Casablanca. It's not all unpalatable though, either the book or a majority of the meals he gets to eat. Majumdar has a laid-back style, spiced with typically British humour, sprinkled with anecdotes and astute descriptions of cities, people and places. And, of course, food, where he is in his element. Food, he writes, is not just what he eats, but what he is and what he does. Starting from Australia, he literally eats his way across continents, leaving a trail of slaughtered animals. There are novel discoveries. He rates Xian, more famous for its terracotta warriors, as having the most delicious food in all of China, and discovers that America's greatest contribution to world cuisine is the sandwich, which is something they have raised to an art form. He's not talking about the better known Pastrami on rye or hamburgers and hot dogs but sandwiches called Po'Boy and Muffuletta, portable food created for working class people on the go.

That is perhaps where 'the Great Majumdar' scores over the myriad other books on foods. His itinerary and budget means his main course, in the literary context, is largely to do with street food, cafés, food markets and restaurants which are not listed in Michelin guides. He is also a strict non-vegetarian, a man for whom animals were seemingly created. Beef in Argentina, chicken covered in chocolate sauce in a cantina in Mexico, Philly cheese steak in, well, Philly, Weißwurst in Munich, suckling pig in Manila and every possible representatives of the fish and fowl family fall prey to his merciless mastication. It's an entertaining, if not entirely wholesome odyssey, which includes a few weeks in India and a meal at the justly famed Bukhara in Delhi's Maurya which he rates among the 10 best meals of his culinary caper. At the end, stuffed like a Christmas goose, he finds himself broke and bloated but richer for the experience. Combining travel, food and food lovers, this is enjoyable fare even if the excessive use of "best" or "most memorable" meal is a bit overcooked. ■



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